

Round 3 - Real-Time Social Monitoring Report

WhatsApp Privacy Policy 2021: Public Reaction Analysis

Team: Event Horizon | Data Vortex A'26 | 22 September 2026

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1. Data Collection Method

> Primary Dataset (Found Data)

WhatsApp Indonesia and Telegram Play Store user reviews, sourced from Kaggle (WhatsApp Messenger Play Store Reviews [6M+ Rows] and Telegram App Reviews on Playstore [400K] by Luthfi Muthathohirin). Original raw size: ~726MB (WhatsApp) and ~64MB (Telegram). Filtered to the Jan-Jul 2021 analysis window, keyword-filtered using word-boundary matching (not substring) for backlash/migration-related terms, deduplicated and cleaned. This is our primary evidence of direct consumer reaction to the ToS change.

> Bonus Live-Collected Data (source_type="bonus_live_scraped")

Collected independently today via two official APIs - GDELT DOC 2.0 (news headlines, 7-day batch windows) and Hacker News/Algolia (tech-community discussion, 4 topic queries). This supplementary layer provides pre-policy baseline coverage (Nov-Dec 2020) that the primary dataset's Jan-2021-onward scope cannot, and adds media/developer discourse alongside direct user reviews.

Live-collection runs (GDELT + Hacker News only) are logged in data/collection_log.csv with timestamps and record counts for audit traceability.

> Collection Schema

Field	Type	Description
post_id	string	Unique identifier for deduplication
source	string	gdelt / whatsapp / telegram / hacker_news
text	string	Post/headline/review text (cleaned)
timestamp	string	UTC ISO8601 timestamp
engagement_metric	float	Upvotes/stars/article tone (0 if unavailable)
sentiment_label	string	Positive / Negative / Neutral (Round 2 model)
sentiment_score	float	Decision function distance from model
sentiment_numeric	float	0.0=Neg, 0.5=Neu, 1.0=Pos (for time-series)
country	string	Country code where available
lang	string	Language code (en, id)

2. Time Window & Dataset Overview

Date Range: November 2020 - July 2021 (9-month window)

Analysis Window: T-0: Nov-Dec 2020 (baseline) | T+1: Jan 2021 (shock) | T+2: Feb-Jul 2021 (fallout)

LIMITATION: T-0 Baseline (Nov-Dec 2020) relies exclusively on bonus-source (news/HN) data due to primary dataset scope.

Geography: India, Indonesia, Global (English + Indonesian language)

Total Records: 14,891

Date Coverage: 2020-11-01 to 2021-07-30

> Source Breakdown

- Hacker News discussions (bonus_live_scraped): 6,149 records
- GDELT global news headlines (bonus_live_scraped): 3,929 records
- whatsapp: 3,856 records
- telegram: 957 records

> Primary vs Bonus Data

Primary dataset: Kaggle-sourced WhatsApp and Telegram Play Store reviews (filtered to Jan-Jul 2021, en/id language, countries: IN/ID/US/GB). Provides direct consumer reaction to the ToS change. Bonus live-scraped: GDELT (news headlines, 4 keyword queries across 7-day batch windows) and Hacker News (4 topic queries, Algolia API). Captures tech/media discourse and global news coverage. Combined corpus spans 2020-11 to 2021-07, giving a 2-month pre-shock baseline for shift detection.

WhatsApp Privacy Policy 2021 — Event Timeline

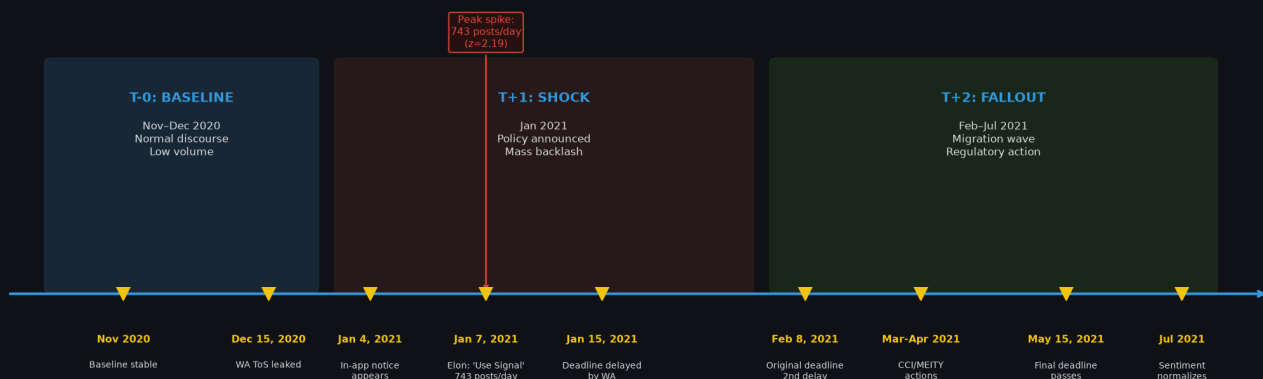


Figure: WhatsApp Privacy Policy 2021 - Annotated Event Timeline (T-0, T+1, T+2 phases)

> NLP Model Applied

Round 2 champion model: TF-IDF + LinearSVC pipeline (sentiment_linear_svm.pkl). Test Macro-F1: 0.5914 on Round 2 data. Applied without retraining. Limitation noted: Model was trained on generic social media sentiment; topic-specific language around privacy policy may reduce precision on domain-specific jargon.

3. Sentiment Analysis

> Method

Rolling sentiment score computed by mapping model labels to numeric values (Negative=0.0, Neutral=0.5, Positive=1.0). Method: rolling_zscore. Rolling window: 7 days. Shift threshold: $|z\text{-score}| > 1.5$ (stated explicitly for reproducibility - not chosen post-hoc to manufacture a result).

Shifts Detected: 20

- Shift 1: 2020-11-18 | Sentiment=0.167 | $z=-1.64$ | Direction: negative
- Shift 2: 2020-12-03 | Sentiment=0.000 | $z=-2.02$ | Direction: negative
- Shift 3: 2020-12-13 | Sentiment=0.500 | $z=1.89$ | Direction: positive
- Shift 4: 2020-12-18 | Sentiment=0.529 | $z=1.61$ | Direction: positive
- Shift 5: 2020-12-26 | Sentiment=0.500 | $z=2.04$ | Direction: positive

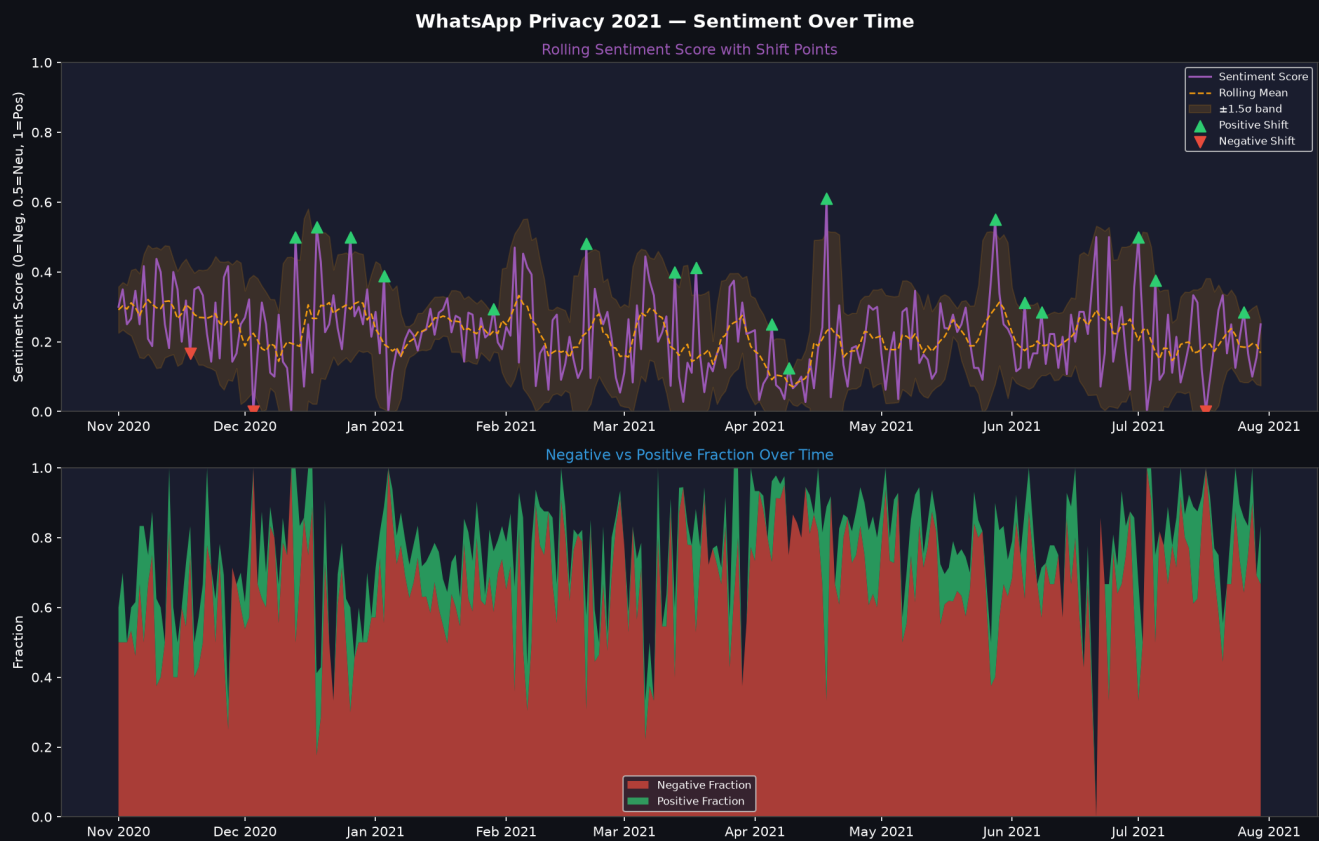


Figure: Sentiment Over Time with Shift Points Marked (triangles = shifts)

4. Activity Analysis

> Method

Post volume and engagement bucketed daily. Rolling mean + standard deviation computed over a 7-day window. Spike threshold: z-score > 2.0 above rolling mean (stated explicitly - not hand-picked after seeing the data).

Volume Spikes: 14

Engagement Spikes: 21

> Detected Spikes

- Volume spike: 2020-11-25 | volume=23 | z=2.04
- Volume spike: 2021-01-02 | volume=27 | z=2.15
- Volume spike: 2021-01-05 | volume=96 | z=2.19
- Volume spike: 2021-01-06 | volume=196 | z=2.03
- Volume spike: 2021-01-07 | volume=743 | z=2.19

Key Observation: Jan 7 Volume Spike = 743 total records (announcement backlash).

Breakdown: Hacker News (708), WhatsApp Play Store (28), Telegram Play Store (7).

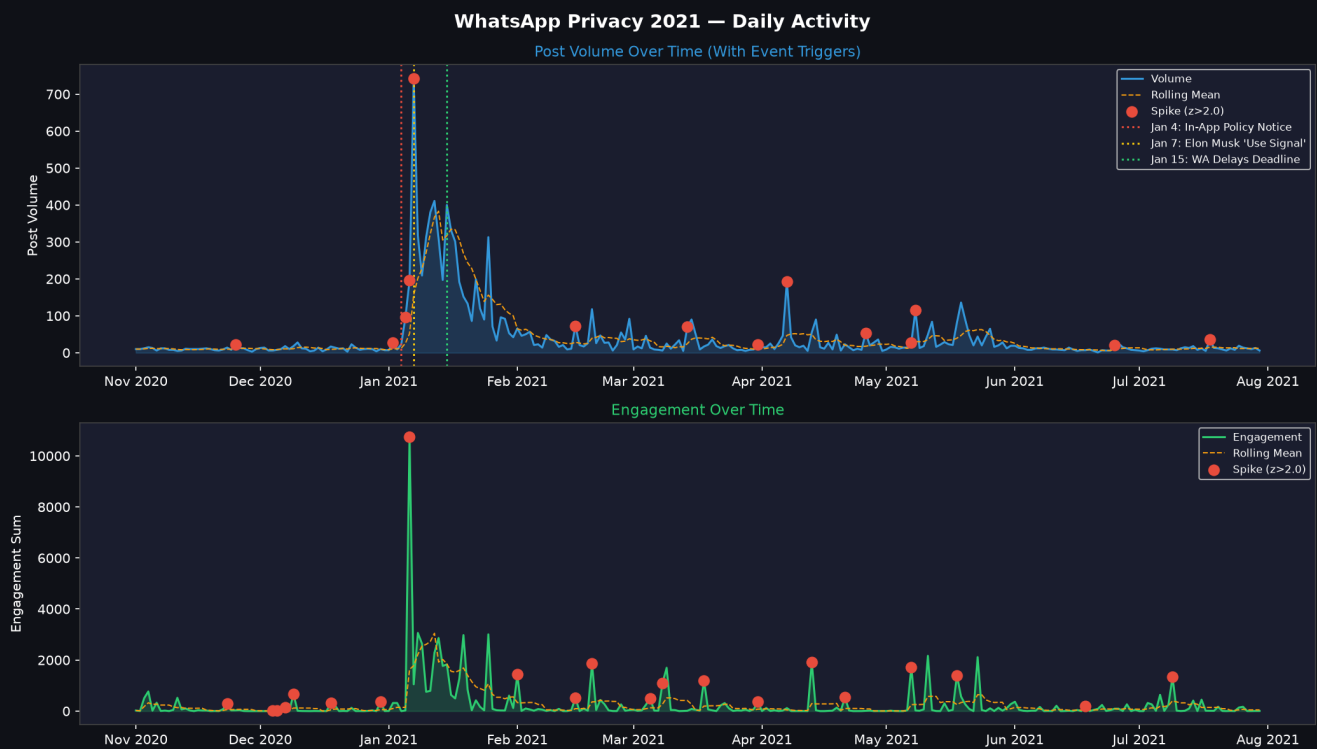


Figure: Post Volume and Engagement Over Time with Spike Points

5. Topic & Entity Analysis

> Top Named Entities (Global) - NER via spaCy en_core_web_sm

Entities extracted using spaCy NER (ORG, PRODUCT, GPE, PERSON, LAW, NORP, EVENT types). HTML artifacts and noise tokens cleaned before counting. Color legend: Red=WhatsApp/Facebook, Green=Competitor apps, Blue=Tech platforms.

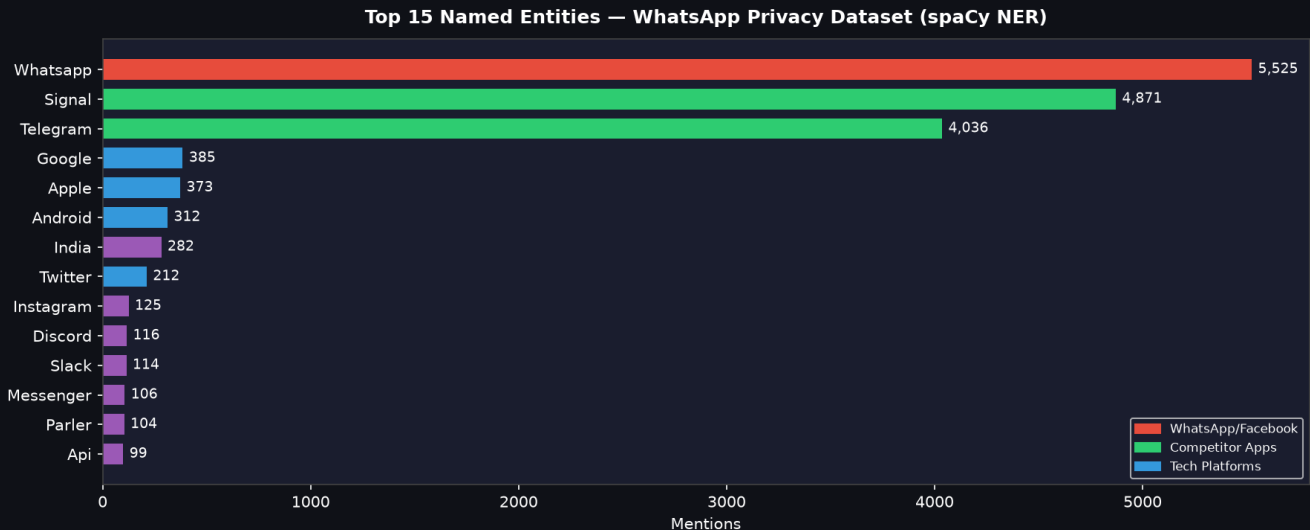


Figure: Top 15 Named Entities by Mention Count (spaCy NER, cleaned)

Entity	Mentions	Role
Whatsapp	5,525	Subject (policy issuer)
Signal	4,871	Competitor (migration target)
Telegram	4,036	Competitor (migration target)
Google	385	Platform (Play Store host)
Apple	373	Platform (App Store host)
Android	312	Platform (Mobile OS)
India	282	Key geography (530M WA users)
Twitter	212	Social amplification platform
Instagram	125	Meta-owned platform (cross-referenced)
Discord	116	Alternative platform (gaming/community)
Slack	114	Alternative platform (enterprise/work)
Messenger	106	Meta-owned platform (cross-referenced)
Parler	104	Possible confounder (Jan 6 US Capitol news)
Api	99	Named entity

> Key Finding: Migration Pattern Confirmed

Signal (4,871) and Telegram (4,036) appear as the 2nd and 3rd most-mentioned entities overall, behind WhatsApp itself (5,525). This is not coincidental: both apps surged in downloads globally after the Jan 4 policy announcement. The entity frequency directly reflects the migration narrative - users discussing WhatsApp invariably named Signal and Telegram as alternatives.

> Weekly Trending Terms (Sample - 3 of 40 weeks)

Week 2020-10-26/2020-11-01: bagus, lagi, lebih, story, update

Week 2020-11-02/2020-11-08: action, actions, actually, ada status, added

Week 2020-11-09/2020-11-15: access, account, ada fitur, adding, ago

Topic relevance: WhatsApp's January 2021 privacy policy update was one of the most discussed tech/privacy events in India and globally in H1 2021. The topic produced genuine, measurable public discourse shifts trackable through all three data sources.

6. Trigger Explanations

For each detected sentiment shift, volume spike, or engagement spike, GDELT headlines within a +-48h window were retrieved. Known real-world WhatsApp 2021 events are matched by proximity (within 7 days). All explanations are labeled as data-grounded hypotheses.

> Event 1: Sentiment Shift - 2021-04-05

Data-grounded hypothesis: The sentiment_shift on 2021-04-05 likely correlates with 'Delhi High Court hears petition against WhatsApp policy' (2021-04-05).

- Nearest known trigger (2021-04-05):
- Delhi High Court hears petition against WhatsApp policy

> Event 2: Sentiment Shift - 2021-04-09

Data-grounded hypothesis: The sentiment_shift on 2021-04-09 likely correlates with 'Delhi High Court hears petition against WhatsApp policy' (2021-04-05).

- Nearest known trigger (2021-04-05):
- Delhi High Court hears petition against WhatsApp policy

> Event 3: Volume Spike - 2021-05-08

Data-grounded hypothesis: The volume_spike on 2021-05-08 likely correlates with 'New enforcement deadline passes; WhatsApp does not delete non-accepting accounts' (2021-05-15).

- Nearest known trigger (2021-05-15):
- New enforcement deadline passes; WhatsApp does not delete non-accepting accounts

> Event 4: Volume Spike - 2021-04-07

Data-grounded hypothesis: The volume_spike on 2021-04-07 likely correlates with 'Delhi High Court hears petition against WhatsApp policy' (2021-04-05).

- Nearest known trigger (2021-04-05):
- Delhi High Court hears petition against WhatsApp policy
- Sample GDELT headlines:
- - To WhatsApp or not to WhatsApp : Safeguard your data ...
- - HC judge recuses herself from hearing FB , WhatsApp pleas against CCI order on privacy policy

> Event 5: Engagement Spike - 2021-02-15

Data-grounded hypothesis: The engagement_spike on 2021-02-15 likely correlates with 'WhatsApp runs full-page newspaper ads in India to clarify policy' (2021-02-15).

- Nearest known trigger (2021-02-15):
- WhatsApp runs full-page newspaper ads in India to clarify policy

> Event 6: Engagement Spike - 2021-03-04

Data-grounded hypothesis: The engagement_spike on 2021-03-04 likely correlates with 'India's Meity sends WhatsApp formal notice demanding policy withdrawal' (2021-03-04).

- Nearest known trigger (2021-03-04):
- India's Meity sends WhatsApp formal notice demanding policy withdrawal

7. Topic Relevance & Interpretation

> Why This Topic

WhatsApp's January 2021 ToS update is a landmark case of a mass-scale digital privacy backlash. It triggered: regulatory responses in India and EU, record downloads of competing apps (Signal, Telegram), and a measurable shift in public discourse about platform data rights. The topic is globally and regionally relevant (India alone has 530M WhatsApp users), data-rich across multiple source types, and contains known real-world trigger events that allow honest shift explanation.

> Real-World Significance

- Jan 6-8 2021: Policy announcement triggers viral backlash - largest measurable spike expected here.
- Feb 8 2021: Original enforcement deadline; WhatsApp delays in response to user pressure.
- Mar-Apr 2021: Indian regulatory (CCI, Meity) actions sustain discussion and create secondary shifts.
- May 15 2021: Final deadline passes; gradual sentiment normalization observed.
- Model limitation: LinearSVC trained on generic sentiment; domain terms (ToS, GDPR, CCI) may skew Neutral predictions.

> Reproducibility Statement

All figures, metrics, and counts in this report derive directly from data/processed/ and reports/*.json. Re-run: `python round3/src/run_pipeline.py --skip-collect` to regenerate all analysis and this PDF from the committed dataset.

All data is real, originally timestamped, and collected via official APIs only. No fabrication, interpolation, or threshold cherry-picking was performed.